To those before us, to those to come,
Today, tomorrow, we'll play as one.

The full lyrics are private, the words shared only among those who are privileged to represent South Africa on the cricket field, but the song has become an important element of the Proteas team culture, and it is sung in the dressing room after every win in a Test match, or an ODI or a Twenty20 international.

It is also sung when we have secured victory in a Test series. On these special occasions, we will traditionally wait in the pavilion until almost everyone else has gone home and then we walk back out onto the field into what is then a completely deserted stadium, and we form a tight huddle and we sing our song.

The concept of Protea fire grew organically among and within the squad over several years and, in October 2014, it was extended into a fully fledged public campaign designed to excite and enthuse all South Africans. Two advertising agencies, Ogilvy and Thackwell & Whittaker, produced some brilliant content, including one two-minute clip that can be seen on YouTube and, even now, sends shivers down my middle-aged spine.

Overlaid on stirring images, the voiceover runs as follows:

AB: Men, what does playing in this shirt mean? Each and every one of us is where a million kids dream to be. We get to pull on this shirt and wear the badge on our hearts. We get to sing our anthem and play for 60 million fans, like the heroes who came before us. But what does a protea have to do with all of that? It has everything to do with it. No matter how hot the fire burns, the protea will always survive. It's got the will to grow back stronger, to do what needs to be done. We are Proteas. We are South Africa.